Literature Review

Data sources

U.S.-based online surveys:
Chinoy et al. (2026); Stantcheva (2021); Alesina et al. (2018)

U.S.-based long-running surveys (repeated cross-section not longitudinal):
General Social Survey (GSS), American National Election Studies (ANES)

International long-running surveys (repeated cross-section not longitudinal):
World/European Values Survey (WVS/EVS), International Social Survey Programme (ISSP)

Macro data
World Inequality Database (WID), World Political Cleavages and Inequality Database (WPID), etc.

Could use:
Understanding America Survey, Microdata on California propositions

Positioning

Our paper's contributions

partly filled out

- Documenting widening age gap
- Comprehensively testing lifecycle self-interest hypotheses
- Comparing explanatory power of circumstances, expectations, values, and beliefs in one survey
- A decomposition of zero-sum beliefs that accounts for attribution/blame in different contexts (in progress)
- Harmonizing online and long-running surveys to compare drivers of support for redistribution (and to decompose the age gap)
- Cross-country and within-US analysis to discover historical drivers of US belief shift/age gap (in progress)

Our survey's advantages

- We observe circumstances, expectations, values, and beliefs of an individual all in one survey, while others tend to focus on a specific mechanism or compare fairness and efficiency, meaning we're well positioned to compare relative importance of mechanisms (even if we reject some of our novel ones).
- Our comprehensive treatment of the lifecycle economic self-interest hypothesis is unique. Detailed questions about one's current financial situation, expected income path, income uncertainty/risk, long-term AI/climate/housing/health risk, and time preference are rare or nonexistent in other academic surveys.
- Importance of zero-sum beliefs is relatively new and other papers do not decompose these views into specific targets/beneficiaries/programs like we do (CEOs, gender, diversity initiatives). Still, we could do a better decomposition in a second wave.
- Other unique/uncommon questions include: our visual tax policy proposal (more concrete than "government should equalize incomes"), self-reported change in preferences plus why it changed (nonexistent elsewhere, could also be improved in second wave), incentive effects (less-common in large surveys), alternative policies to support low-income (useful for disentangling channels), and whether hard work and education has/will pay off (other measures of mobility more common).
- Our 2025 sample provides a valuable post-2024 view of beliefs and preferences, and we have a large sample in the 18-29 range (many surveys are noisier in that range).

Closest relatives

Ashok, Kuziemko, and Washington (2015)
Support for redistribution in the U.S. has fallen among the elderly, possibly because they fear universal programs crowding out Medicare.

Chinoy, Nunn, Sequeira, and Stantcheva (2026)
A more zero-sum mindset is strongly associated with more support for government redistribution. Zero-sum thinking is associated with the degree of intergenerational upward mobility, immigration, and slavery of an individual and their ancestors.

Belief formation

Shared history

Mannheim (1952)
Generations are shaped not by simple biological aging, but by shared social and historical locations during formative years.

Alesina and Fuchs-Schündeln (2007)
Time spent under Communism increases demand for redistribution. Tested in East Germany.

Fuchs-Schündeln and Schündeln (2015)
Time spent under democracy increases support for democracy.

Landier, Thesmar, and Thoenig (2008)
Evidence of slow, home-biased and path-dependent learning about the comparative virtues of economic systems.

Formative years

Krosnick and Alwin (1989)
Using ANES data, the authors find support for the impressionable years hypothesis (highly susceptible to change in late adolescence/early adulthood) over the increasing persistence hypothesis (gradually more resistant to change over lifecycle) for political attitudes.

Malmendier and Nagel (2011)
Early "individual experiences of macroeconomic shocks" paper. Individuals who experienced low stock market returns throughout their lives reported lower willingness to take financial risk, with stronger effects on young people.

Roth and Wohlfart (2018)
People who have experienced higher inequality during their lives are less in favor of redistribution. Uses European Social Survey, U.S. GSS, and German GSS.

Recessions

Carreri and Teso (2023)
Politicians who experienced a recession hold more conservative positions on redistribution.

Giuliano and Spilimbergo (2023)
Individuals who experienced a recession when young are less in favor of redistribution, evidence for impressionable years hypothesis. Uses regional variation in U.S. GSS, validated by Integrated Values Survey (WVS/EVS).

Comparative

Bergeron, Carvalho, Henrich, Nunn, and Weigel (2023)
Demotivating beliefs (envy of others, belief in the importance of luck, disdain for competitive effort, and traditional beliefs in witchcraft) evolve when interactions are zero-sum, i.e., one person's gain comes at the expense of others.

U.S. trends/uniqueness

Inequality

Overall/low-income growth

Absolute mobility

Chetty, Grusky, Hell, Hendren, Manduca, and Narang (2017)
Declining absolute mobility.

Political institutions/power

Alesina, Glaeser, and Sacerdote (2001)
Differences between the US and European welfare states appear to be the result of racial heterogeneity in the US and American political institutions limiting the political power of the poor and the growth of a socialist party.

Media/narratives

Correlates of redistributive preferences

Culture

Alesina and Giuliano (2011)
Handbook review of preferences for redistribution. Emphasizes the role of historical experiences, cultural factors, and personal history.

Luttmer and Singhal (2011)
Immigrants from high-preference countries are more likely to vote for pro-redistribution parties.

Generosity/altruism

Landier and Thesmar (2022)
Support for deviation from efficient solutions is strongly correlated with moral values as defined by Haidt (2013): care, fairness, loyalty and authority. While the traditional left-right divide spans some of this variation, an even bigger role is played by what we label "individualism."

In-group preferences

Enke (2020)
Heterogeneity in adherence to universalist values (individual rights, justice, impartial fairness, and avoidance of externalities) versus communal/particularist values (community, loyalty, betrayal, respect, and tradition) helps explain modern U.S. voting shifts.

Alesina, Miano, and Stantcheva (2023)
Simply making respondents think about immigration before asking questions about redistribution makes them support less redistribution. The perception that immigrants are economically weaker and more likely to take advantage of the welfare system is strongly correlated with lower support for redistribution.

Fischbacher, Grammling, Hausfeld, and Zíka (2023)
In a lab setting, ingroup favoritism is a strong motive for redistribution in general, and it is the most important motive for redistribution to increase or reverse inequality.

Londoño-Vélez (2022)
Exposure to low-income peers caused high-income students to diversify their social networks, have more accurate perceptions of the income distribution, and support progressive redistribution.

Zero-sum beliefs

Wilkins, Wellman, Babbitt, Toosi, and Schad (2015)
When high status groups perceive discrimination against them, they espouse zero-sum beliefs.

Davidai and Ongis (2019)
Conservatives view social inequalities—where the status quo is frequently challenged—as zero-sum, but liberals view economic inequalities—where the status quo has remained relatively unchallenged—as zero-sum.

Chinoy, Nunn, Sequeira, and Stantcheva (2026)

A more zero-sum mindset is strongly associated with more support for government redistribution. Zero-sum thinking is associated with the degree of intergenerational upward mobility, immigration, and slavery of an individual and their ancestors.

Fairness/equal opportunity

Fong (2001)
Self- and exogenous-determination beliefs have large and significant effects on support for redistribution. A likely interpretation is that people are reciprocal or hold strong principles of equity.

Alesina and La Ferrara (2005)
People who believe that American society offers equal opportunities are more averse to redistribution.

Cappelen, Hole, Sørensen, and Tungodden (2007)
In a lab setting, estimates the prevalence of three principles of distributive justice (strict egalitarianism, liberal egalitarianism, and libertarianism) and the distribution of the weight attached to fairness.

Durante, Putterman, and Van der Weele (2014)
Lab experiment to study how demand for redistribution of income depends on self-interest, insurance motives, and social concerns relating to inequality and efficiency.

Stantcheva (2021)
Support for income and estate taxes is most strongly correlated with perceived fairness of inequality and taxation and broader views of the government, while efficiency concerns play a minor role.

Fehr, Epper, and Senn (2026)
Uncovers three fundamentally distinct social preference types: predominantly selfish, inequality averse, and altruistic individuals. Inequality averse and altruistic individuals display a much stronger support for redistribution, and for them, beliefs about the role of effort and luck for success are highly relevant. Between the two, altruistic individuals are considerably less supportive of policies aimed at reducing the incomes of the rich.

Policy framing

Kuziemko, Longuet-Marx, and Naidu (2026)
Less-educated Americans differentially demand predistribution policies (e.g., a federal jobs guarantee, higher minimum wages, protectionism, and stronger unions), while more-educated Americans differentially favor redistribution (taxes and transfers).

Reference groups/relative position

Kuziemko, Buell, Reich, and Norton (2014)
Low-income individuals might oppose redistribution because it could differentially help the group just beneath them.

Cruces, Perez-Truglia, and Tetaz (2013)
Those who overestimate their relative position tend to demand higher levels of redistribution when informed of their true ranking.

Karadja, Mollerstrom, and Seim (2017)
Individuals who are richer than they initially thought demand less redistribution.

Hoy and Mager (2021)

Contrary to prevailing wisdom, people who are told they are relatively poorer than they thought are less concerned about inequality and are not more supportive of redistribution.

Hvidberg, Kreiner, and Stantcheva (2023)

People view inequalities within their co-workers and education groups as significantly more unfair than overall inequality, yet underestimate inequality the most exactly within these groups. Lower-ranked respondents in all groups tend to overestimate their own position among others.

Perceptions about inequality/mobility

Norton and Ariely (2011)

Individuals in the U.S. dramatically overestimate the degree of equality in the wealth distribution and select an even more equal distribution than their estimates.

Kuziemko, Norton, Saez, and Stantcheva (2015)

An information treatment has large effects on views about inequality but only slightly moves tax and transfer policy preferences. This is partially explained by respondents' low trust in government.

Alesina, Stantcheva, and Teso (2018)

Pessimistic information about mobility and increases support for redistribution, but not for right-wing respondents, possibly because they do not see the government as the solution.

Economic insecurity/self-interest

Sears and Funk (1990)

Unless the short-term economic effect is very direct, self-interest is not a very significant or large predictor of policy preferences, and "symbolic" attitudes have much more influence.

Bossert, Clark, D'ambrosio, and Lepinteur (2023)

Conditional on current economic resources, economic insecurity is associated with both greater political participation and more support for conservative parties.

Melcher (2023)

Economic insecurity has a systematic and strong effect on the redistributive, class, and racial attitudes of Americans. Economic insecurity—one's worry or anxiety regarding the potential of future economic hardship—and cognitive economic insecurity—an individual's more or less dispassionate estimate of future economic hardship—often have distinct and complementary effects.

Theory

Demand for redistribution

Meltzer and Richard (1981)

Inequality increases demand for redistribution. An increase in mean income relative to the income of the decisive voter increases the size of government.

Fehr and Schmidt (1999)

Introduces the concept of inequality aversion; equality per se having value.

Benabou and Ok (2001)

Prospect of upward mobility (POUM) decreases demand for redistribution. However, the authors conclude the POUM channel is probably dominated by the demand for social insurance.

Find these papers: "Economic models suggest that redistribution is a function of the variance and skewness of the pre-tax income distribution, the volatility of income, the social costs of taxation and the expected income mobility of the median voter."

Societal equilibria

Piketty (1995)

Left-wing dynasties believing less in individual effort and voting for more redistribution coexist with right-wing dynasties.

Piketty (1998)

If a society infers better traits from one's social status (implying they believe less in luck), then, ironically, income inequality may become more persistent. This is because the rich are more motivated to stay rich.

Alesina and Angeletos (2005)

If a society believes that luck, birth, connections, and/or corruption determine wealth, it will levy high taxes, thus distorting allocations and making these beliefs self-sustained.

Benabou and Tirole (2006)

Belief in a just world and redistributive politics. An "American" equilibrium with a high prevalence of just-world beliefs and a relatively laissez- faire public policy, and a "European" equilibrium with more pessimism and a more extensive welfare state.

from previous review:

Related survey questions

Armantier et al. (2017) "An overview of the survey of consumer expectations"

Falk et al. (2018) "Global evidence on economic preferences"

Strathman et al. (1994) "The consideration of future consequences: Weighing immediate and distant outcomes of behavior"

Enke et al. (2023) "Moral universalism and the structure of ideology"

Not yet summarized

Almås et al. (2020) "Cutthroat capitalism versus cuddly socialism: Are Americans more meritocratic and efficiency-seeking than Scandinavians?"

Rehm (2009) "Risks and redistribution: An individual-level analysis"

Margalit (2013) "Explaining social policy preferences: Evidence from the Great Recession"

Piketty et al. (2014) "Optimal taxation of top labor incomes: A tale of three elasticities"

Stantcheva (2024) "Perceptions and preferences for redistribution"

SoRelle and Laws (2023) "The political benefits of student loan debt relief"

Ansell (2014) "The political economy of ownership: Housing markets and the welfare state"

Furtado and Flynn (2025) "Housing unaffordability and political preferences among young people in Europe"

Steele (2020) "Wealth and preferences for redistribution: The effects of financial assets and home equity in 31 countries"

Alesina et al. (2021) "Perceptions of Racial Gaps, their Causes, and Ways to Reduce Them"

Ali et al. (2025) "The Political Economy of Zero-Sum Thinking"

Bonnet et al. (2025) "What explains preferences for redistribution? Evidence from an international survey"

Busemeyer et al. (2009) "Attitudes towards redistributive spending in an era of demographic ageing: the rival pressures from age and income in 14 OECD countries"

Cappelen et al. (2013) "Just Luck: An Experimental Study of Risk-Taking and Fairness"

Cappelen et al. (2025) "Universalism: Global Evidence"

Carstensen et al. (1999) "Taking time seriously: A theory of socioemotional selectivity."

Cavaillé (2023) "Fair Enough?: Support for Redistribution in the Age of Inequality"

Cojocaru (2014) "Prospects of upward mobility and preferences for redistribution: Evidence from the Life in Transition Survey"

Corneo and Grüner (2002) "Individual preferences for political redistribution"

Cox (2024) "Great expectations: The effect of unmet labor market expectations after higher education on ideology"

Cusack et al. (2006) "Risks at Work: The Demand and Supply Sides of Government Redistribution"

Cutler et al. (2021) "Older adults across the globe exhibit increased prosocial behavior but also greater in-group preferences"

Eaton and Rosen (1980) "Optimal Redistributive Taxation and Uncertainty"

Frohlich et al. (1987) "Laboratory Results on Rawls's Distributive Justice"

Fullerton and Dixon (2010) "Generational Conflict Or Methodological Artifact?"

Gärtner et al. (2017) "Individual risk preferences and the demand for redistribution"

Gelbach (2016) "When Do Covariates Matter? And Which Ones, and How Much?"

Gethin et al. (2022) "Brahmin Left Versus Merchant Right: Changing Political Cleavages in 21 Western Democracies, 1948–2020"

Giuliano and Spilimbergo (2025) "Aggregate Shocks and the Formation of Preferences and Beliefs"

Goerres and Tepe (2010) "Age-based self-interest, intergenerational solidarity and the welfare state: A comparative analysis of older people's attitudes towards public childcare in 12 OECD countries"

Harsanyi (1953) "Cardinal Utility in Welfare Economics and in the Theory of Risk-taking"

Harsanyi (1955) "Cardinal Welfare, Individualistic Ethics, and Interpersonal Comparisons of Utility"

Huettner and Sunder (2012) "Axiomatic arguments for decomposing goodness of fit according to Shapley and Owen values"

Iversen and Soskice (2001) "An Asset Theory of Social Policy Preferences"

Jocker et al. (2024) "Growing Up in a Polarized Party System: Ideological Divergence and Partisan Sorting Across Generations"

Kenworthy and McCall (2007) "Inequality, public opinion and redistribution"

Krawczyk (2010) "A glimpse through the veil of ignorance: Equality of opportunity and support for redistribution"

KURER and VAN STAALDUINEN (2022) "Disappointed Expectations: Downward Mobility and Electoral Change"

Lin et al. (2018) "Is it the government's responsibility to reduce income inequality? An age-period-cohort analysis of public opinion toward redistributive policy in the United States, 1978 to 2016"

Luttmer (2001) "Group Loyalty and the Taste for Redistribution"

Meuleman (2019) "The economic context of solidarity. Period vs. cohort differences in support for income redistribution in Britain and the United States"

Moene and Wallerstein (2001) "Inequality, Social Insurance, and Redistribution"

Munger (2022) "Generation Gap: Why the Baby Boomers Still Dominate American Politics and Culture"

O'Grady (2023) "Is ideological polarisation by age group growing in Europe?"

Owens and Pedulla (2013) "Material Welfare and Changing Political Preferences: The Case of Support for Redistributive Social Policies"

Pittau et al. (2016) "Has the attitude of US citizens towards redistribution changed over time?"

Rainer and Siedler (2008) "Subjective income and employment expectations and preferences for redistribution"

Ravallion and Lokshin (2000) "Who wants to redistribute?"

Rawls (1971) "A Theory of Justice"

REHM et al. (2012) "Insecure Alliances: Risk, Inequality, and Support for the Welfare State"

Roberts et al. (2006) "Patterns of mean-level change in personality traits across the life course: A meta-analysis of longitudinal studies."

Shorrocks (2013) "Decomposition procedures for distributional analysis: a unified framework based on the Shapley value"

Sinn (1995) "A Theory of the Welfare State"

Thewissen and Rueda (2019) "Automation and the Welfare State: Technological Change as a Determinant of Redistribution Preferences"

VanHeuvelen and Copas (2018) "The Intercohort Dynamics of Support for Redistribution in 54 Countries, 1985–2017"

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